PRESS RELEASE

# Two California Residents Plead Guilty in Connection with $16M Hospice Fraud Scheme and Money Laundering Scheme

Tuesday, July 8, 2025

**For Immediate Release**

Office of Public Affairs

Two California residents pleaded guilty yesterday in connection with their roles in defrauding Medicare of nearly $16 million through sham hospice companies and to laundering the proceeds of the fraud as part of a multi-year scheme.

According to court documents, Karpis Srapyan, 35, of Winnetka, California, conspired with others, including co-defendants Petros Fichidzhyan and Juan Carlos Esparza, to bill Medicare for hospice services that were not medically necessary and never provided. To conduct their fraudulent scheme, they used a series of four sham hospice companies: one owned by Esparza and the other three owned by foreign nationals but controlled by the defendants. Srapyan and his co-defendants concealed the scheme by using foreign nationals' personal identifying information to open bank accounts, submit information to Medicare, and sign property leases. They also misappropriated names and other identifying information of several doctors, two of whom were deceased, to fraudulently bill Medicare for purported hospice services. In total, Medicare paid the fake hospice companies nearly $16 million.

Fichidzhyan, Esparza, and Srapyan worked with others to launder the fraudulent proceeds from their hospice scheme. Susanna Harutyunyan, 39, of Winnetka, was aware that her husband and co-defendant Mihran Panosyan was involved in illegal activity with Srapyan and Fichidzhyan. As part of the money laundering scheme, Harutyunyan and her co-defendants maintained fraudulent identification documents, bank documents, checkbooks, and credit and debit cards in the names of purported foreign owners in the residence where she and Panosyan lived and another residence that was owned in her name. Srapyan conducted dozens of financial transactions, totaling approximately $3.2 million, moving funds between accounts in the names of the sham hospice companies, accounts in the names of foreign nationals that were controlled by the defendants, and other accounts involved in the money laundering scheme. Harutyunyan knowingly spent fraudulent proceeds on personal expenses, including payments for a BMW automobile.

Srapyan pleaded guilty to conspiracy to commit health care fraud and money laundering and is scheduled to be sentenced on Oct. 6. He faces a maximum penalty of 20 years in prison. Harutyunyan pleaded guilty to money laundering and is scheduled to be sentenced on Nov. 17; she faces a maximum penalty of 10 years in prison. A federal district court judge will determine their sentences after considering the U.S. Sentencing Guidelines and other statutory factors. Harutyunyan faces deportation.

Co-defendant Petros Fichidzhyan previously pleaded guilty to health care fraud, aggravated identity theft, and money laundering. In May, Fichidzhyan was sentenced to 12 years in prison. Co-defendant Mihran Panosyan pleaded guilty to money laundering in June and is scheduled to be sentenced Sept. 8. Co-defendant Juan Carlos Esparza's change of plea hearing is scheduled for July 14.

The guilty pleas today are the most recent convictions in the Justice Department's ongoing effort to combat hospice fraud in the greater Los Angeles area. Last year, a doctor was convicted at trial for his role in a scheme to bill Medicare for hospice services patients did not need, and two other defendants were sentenced for their roles in a hospice fraud scheme.

Matthew R. Galeotti, Head of the Justice Department's Criminal Division, Assistant Director in Charge Akil Davis of the FBI Los Angeles Field Office, and Deputy Inspector General for Investigations Christian J. Schrank of the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services Office of the Inspector General (HHS-OIG) made the announcement.

The FBI and HHS-OIG are investigating the case.

Trial Attorneys Michael Bacharach, Sarah E. Edwards, and Allison L. McGuire of the Criminal Division's Fraud Section are prosecuting the case, and Assistant U.S. Attorney Tara B. Vavere for the Central District of California is handling asset forfeiture.

The Fraud Section leads the Criminal Division's efforts to combat health care fraud through the Health Care Fraud Strike Force Program. Since March 2007, this program, currently comprised of 9 strike forces operating in 27 federal districts, has charged more than 5,800 defendants who collectively have billed federal health care programs and private insurers more than $30 billion. In addition, the Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, working in conjunction with HHS-OIG, are taking steps to hold providers accountable for their involvement in health care fraud schemes. More information can be found at www.justice.gov/criminal-fraud/health-care-fraud-unit.

*Updated July 8, 2025*

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**Topic**

**HEALTHCARE FRAUD**

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